

By Amarnath K. Menon

The Deccan Chargers (dc) must be confused: their 'home turf', the unshakeable Deccan plateau, suddenly shifted a few hundred miles in every direction. It was not a geographical phenomenon but political and logistical circumstance, typical of the annual burlesque, cricket's Indian Premier League (IPL).

Ideally, dc, the tournament's defending champions, would face Kolkata Knight Riders before their real 'faithful' in Hyderabad and kick off IPL Season 3. Their calendar now offers three of seven 'home' games in Nagpur and two each in Cuttack and Mumbai. The blame, say dc, is not theirs, but of the IPL, whose enormous successes of its first 2008 season have reaped many problems later. (see box) As the countdown to Season 3 shrinks to less than a month, the prospect of peril increases.

The prominence of the IPL has made it a powerful magnet for doubt and debate, be it protests against cheerleaders, security concerns, the Telangana issue or faux nationalism. Last year, India's most glamorous sports event had to move to South Africa, due to a clash with the General Elections.

Now that it's "coming home", so is fresh trouble: fractious politics in Andhra Pradesh, the growing noise of sabotage by the Shiv Sena and even a potential Al-Qaeda warning have become central in the IPL's life cycle and a wrangle with broadcasters has added to the IPL's overflowing cup of woes.

The decision to shift dc's matches from Hyderabad and Visakhapatnam was announced by IPL Chairman Lalit Modi—but on his Twitter account. As if moving a city franchise's home game was as significant as a personal whim. dc threatened to pull out of the event, its legal notice to the organisers saying that the decision to move matches was "arbitrarily and unilaterally without our consent and in complete breach of the franchise agreement... to which the rights and obligations of both parties BCCI-IPL and the franchise are governed".

The IPL though, says CEO Sundar Raman, had followed events in the

“ Changing venues in this manner makes the country seem unsafe and sends wrong signals to global investors. ”

KONIJETI ROSAIAH

Chief Minister, Andhra Pradesh



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The Cup OF WOES

Controversy seems to precede, and follow, the IPL. The third season hasn't begun but a row is on in the middle.

state for "forty days" from December to February during which not all was fine in the Andhra capital. An India vs Sri Lanka ODI was moved from Hyderabad to Nagpur, a Duleep Trophy game was held in an empty stadium, the Ranji one-day south zone league was moved to Chennai and 100 attackers invaded the pitch during a dc practice match between a Hyderabad XI and an Andhra Pradesh XI. Modi says the decision to move matches to Cuttack was "keeping in mind the catchment area and the sentiment of fans... and I hope they will come out in large numbers to support their team at the Barabati Stadium". It would be an inspiring sight: a 1,100-km journey to Cuttack for a dc home game.

dc may have little to cheer in

Cuttack though it can be said that owner T. Venkatram Reddy, as the owner of the fast growing *Deccan Chronicle* newspaper, can eye opportunities for expanding his media enterprise in Orissa. It is being said that dc reversed its earlier stance of pulling out of IPL-3 and had sought the Cuttack change. Venkat Reddy, director, Operations, dc says that the announcement by the Hyderabad Cricket Association to the IPL after the incidents mentioned was, "in no way alarming".

Andhra Pradesh's separate statehood campaigners have also said that they will not disrupt the IPL. The state police are not willing to take chances in the face of the ongoing agitation for Telangana, with the main apprehension being